

JJ PREMIER GROUP

GUIDE NO. 08

Barrier island rules, island by island

Which government makes the rules on each island, the three rules that change at the bridge, and how to check them for one house.

BY JOELYN NAUMAN · UPDATED OCTOBER 2, 2026 · 10 MIN READ

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How to use this guide

Read this guide once from start to finish. Then use the checklist at the end each time you look at a house on an island.

Rules change, and each city reads them its own way. Each part of this guide tells you where its facts come from. Before you count on a rule for one house, check it with the city or county that runs the island.

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As you read, keep coming back to three questions

1. Which government runs this island?
2. What is the zoning district for this lot?
3. What does that district allow?

01

Five islands, five sets of rules

From the water, the islands look alike. The rules don't. Each island answers to its own city or county.

A barrier island is a long, thin island that sits between the Gulf and the bay. You reach it by a bridge. Our coast has a chain of them.

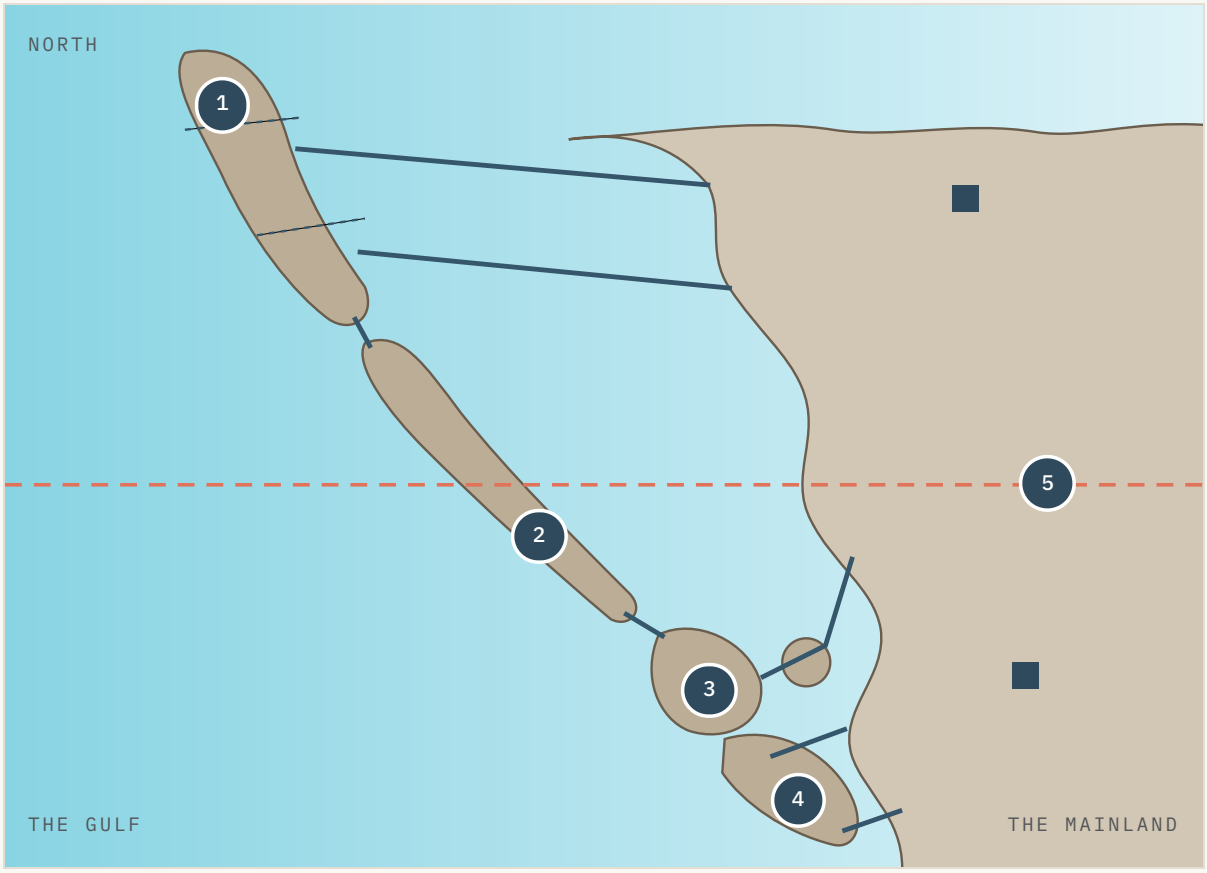
Anna Maria Island is three small cities: Anna Maria, Holmes Beach and Bradenton Beach. Longboat Key is one town, but the county line runs through it. Lido Key and St. Armands are part of the City of Sarasota. Siesta Key has no city hall of its own. A small piece at its north end is in the city, and the rest is run by Sarasota County.

Three rules come up on every island. How tall can you build? How short can a rental be? And what happens when a storm wrecks half the house? Each government answers them its own way. So look up the rules for the exact lot, not the island.

FIG. 01 · THE ISLANDS FROM ABOVE

Who makes the rules on each island

North is at the top. Find the island, then read its entry below the drawing.



1 Anna Maria Island
Three cities. Anna Maria is at the north end, Holmes Beach in the middle and Bradenton Beach at the south end. The dashed lines are the city lines.

2 Longboat Key
One town. The county line crosses it, so part of the town is in Manatee County and part is in Sarasota County.

3 Lido Key and St. Armands
Both are inside the City of Sarasota. The city makes the rules here.

4 Siesta Key
No city of its own. The north end is inside the City of Sarasota. The rest is Sarasota County.

5 The county line
Manatee County is north of this line and Sarasota County is south of it. Each county sets its own property tax rate.

This drawing shows the idea, not a real map. The islands are not to scale.

Source: Town of Longboat Key, Ad valorem taxes; Sarasota City Plan, Environmental protection and coastal islands chapter; the three cities' and the town's pages listed under this section

02

The rule that shapes every rebuild

This rule is federal, so it's the same on every island. It decides what happens after a big storm or a big remodel.

Picture a house on a canal. A storm fills it with water. The repair bill comes to more than half of what the house is worth.

Now the house can't just be fixed as it was. It must be rebuilt to the rules for a new house. On these islands, that means raising it above the big flood.

SUBSTANTIAL IMPROVEMENT

Work on a building that costs half or more of what the building is worth. The value is the building's, not the land's. Once work crosses that line, the whole building must meet today's rules for a new one.

Source: FEMA, Substantial improvement (glossary)

Storm damage counts the same way. If the damage comes to half the building's value, any repair counts, even if you only fix part of it.

The counting matters. In Manatee County, work is added up over one year. A kitchen this spring and a roof next winter can count as one project. Ask the building department for a written decision before you plan.

FIG. 02 · THE LINE

Under half, or half and more

Read each side. The cost of the work, compared with the building's value, decides which side you're on.

WORK THAT COSTS LESS THAN HALF

Fix it or improve it as it was

- Get the normal permits
- The lowest floor can stay where it is

WORK THAT COSTS HALF OR MORE

The whole building must meet today's rules for a new one

1. On the islands, that means raising it above the big flood
2. Storm damage counts, even if you only fix part of it
3. In Manatee County, work is added up over one year
4. Ask the building department for a written decision

Source: FEMA, Substantial improvement (glossary); City of Holmes Beach, Flood and hurricane protection information; Manatee County, Floodplain management

03

Anna Maria Island: three cities

One island, three city halls. The rental rules and the height limits change at the city line.

Anna Maria, at the north end, licenses every vacation rental. You need a city registration, a state tax registration, and a state license as a transient public lodging establishment. That last one is the state's name for a place rented out for short stays. You can't advertise or rent until the city's inspection is passed. The city's page doesn't give a shortest stay or a height limit, so ask the city.

Holmes Beach, in the middle, requires a vacation rental certificate for every rental. The shortest stay follows the zoning district. In R-1 and R-1AA it's 30 days, and the home can be rented only once in any 30 days. In R-2, R-3 and R-4 it's one week.

Holmes Beach caps height at 36 feet. It measures from the crown of the road in front of the house to the top of the roof.

Bradenton Beach, at the south end, counts how often a home is rented. Rent it more than three times a year for stays under 30 days, and it's a short-term rental. That takes a state registration and a city license, which the city calls a transient public lodging establishment license. In its R-2 district, a building can rise 29 feet above the flood protection elevation, and no more than two stories and a loft.

Each city measures height from a different starting line. So you can't compare the numbers straight across. Ask each city where its line is for the lot.

FIG. 03 · THREE CITIES

The rule on each part of the island

Each card is one city, from north to south. The link opens the city's own page.

01

NORTH END

City of Anna Maria

Every vacation rental needs a city registration, a state lodging license and a state tax registration. No advertising or renting until the inspection is passed. The page gives no shortest stay or height limit, so ask the city.

CITYOFANNAMARIA.COM

02

MIDDLE

City of Holmes Beach

Every rental needs a vacation rental certificate. Shortest stay: 30 days in R-1 and R-1AA, and one week in R-2, R-3 and R-4. Height: 36 feet, measured from the crown of the road.

HOLMESBEACHFL.ORG

03

SOUTH END

City of Bradenton Beach

Rented more than three times a year for stays under 30 days? That's a short-term rental. It needs a state registration and a city lodging license. Height in R-2: 29 feet above the flood protection elevation, two stories and a loft.

CITYOFBRADENTONBEACH.COM

Source: City of Anna Maria, Vacation rental rules and regulations; City of Holmes Beach, Vacation rental certificates and Comprehensive plan; City of Bradenton Beach, Common code violations and R-2 district sheet

04

Longboat Key: one town, two counties

The county line crosses the island. The town makes the rental rules, but your county sets your property tax rate.

Picture two houses a block apart. Same town, same beach. One is in Manatee County and one is in Sarasota County. They pay different county tax rates.

The town's rental rule is simple to state. In residential zoning, the shortest rental is 30 days in a row, or one full calendar month. The exceptions are homes in a tourism district, and homes with an old tourism use the town let stand.

Any home rented for less than six months goes on the town's rental registry, which it calls the Residential Rental Registry. The registry started on October 1, 2023. The town inspects the home, and the certificate number must appear in every ad.

We didn't find a height limit on the town's pages. Ask the planning division before you count on a number.

FIG. 04 · WHO DECIDES WHAT

The county and the town answer different questions

Read each side. The county answers the money and voting questions. The town answers the rental ones.

THE COUNTY DECIDES

Your property tax rate and where you vote

- Manatee County and Sarasota County each set their own tax rate
- Each county has its own property appraiser and tax collector

THE TOWN DECIDES

How short a rental can be

1. 30 days in a row, or one full calendar month, in residential zoning
2. A tourism district, or an old tourism use, can allow shorter stays
3. Rentals under six months go on the town's registry
4. A town inspection, and the certificate number in every ad

Source: Town of Longboat Key: Ad valorem taxes, Elections, Short term rentals, Residential rental registry

05

Lido Key and St. Armands: the City of Sarasota

These keys are part of the city. The city's rental rule is short: seven days and seven nights, with a certificate.

The rule applies to houses and small buildings with one to four units, in the city's residential zoning districts. Before you rent, you register with the city and pass its inspection. The city calls the paper you get a vacation rental certificate of registration. Then each stay must be at least seven full days and seven full nights.

The rule doesn't apply if you live in the home yourself. It also skips condominiums and cooperatives, which follow their own documents. And it skips stays of 30 days or more.

Height here comes from the city's plan, which has a height map for the coastal islands. On much of Lido Key and St. Armands, the limit is 35 feet, measured from the minimum FEMA elevation. That's the height the big flood would reach. The resort district along the Gulf on southern Lido allows much taller buildings.

Which rule applies depends on the zoning district. The city's zoning maps are on its GIS page, and its zoning staff can tell you the district for an address.

FIG. 05 · THE CITY'S RULE

Three questions the city's rental rule turns on

Answer each one for the house. The note under the questions tells you what the answers mean.

1	**Is it a house, or a building with one to four units, in a residential zoning district?**	☐ YES	☐ NO
2	**Will guests stay for less than 30 days?**	☐ YES	☐ NO
3	**Do you live there yourself, or is it a condominium or a cooperative?** If so, the city's registration rule doesn't apply. A condominium follows its own documents.	☐ YES	☐ NO

If the first two answers are yes and the third is no, the city's rule applies. Register, pass the inspection, and rent for seven days and seven nights at a time. These are plain-language versions of the city's rule, which uses its own words.

Source: City of Sarasota, Vacation rentals; City of Sarasota, Zoning; Sarasota City Plan, Environmental protection and coastal islands chapter

06

Siesta Key: Sarasota County

Most of Siesta Key has no city hall. Its rules come from Sarasota County.

This guide doesn't cover the county's rental or height rules. Read them in the county's code, or call its planning office.

Here's what we can tell you. Florida law limits what a city or county can do about vacation rentals. A local rule can't ban them, and it can't set how long or how often a home is rented. But rules adopted on or before June 1, 2011 were allowed to stay. So the date a rule was written matters.

The 50 percent rule applies on Siesta Key too. It's federal. And the north end of the key is inside the City of Sarasota, where the city's rules apply.

FIG. 06 · WHERE TO LOOK

Three places to read Siesta Key's rules

Start with the county. The other two tell you how to read what you find.

01

MOST OF SIESTA KEY

Sarasota County

The county's own site. Start here, or call the county's planning office.

SCGOV.NET

02

THE COUNTY'S CODE

Sarasota County code of ordinances

The county's rules, chapter by chapter, on Municode.

LIBRARY.MUNICODE.COM

03

STATE LAW

Florida Statutes 509.032

The law that limits what local rental rules can do, and the June 1, 2011 date.

FLSENATE.GOV

Source: Florida Statutes 509.032(7) (2026); Sarasota City Plan, which puts the north end of Siesta Key inside the city; Sarasota County, scgov.net

07

The shortest stay, island by island

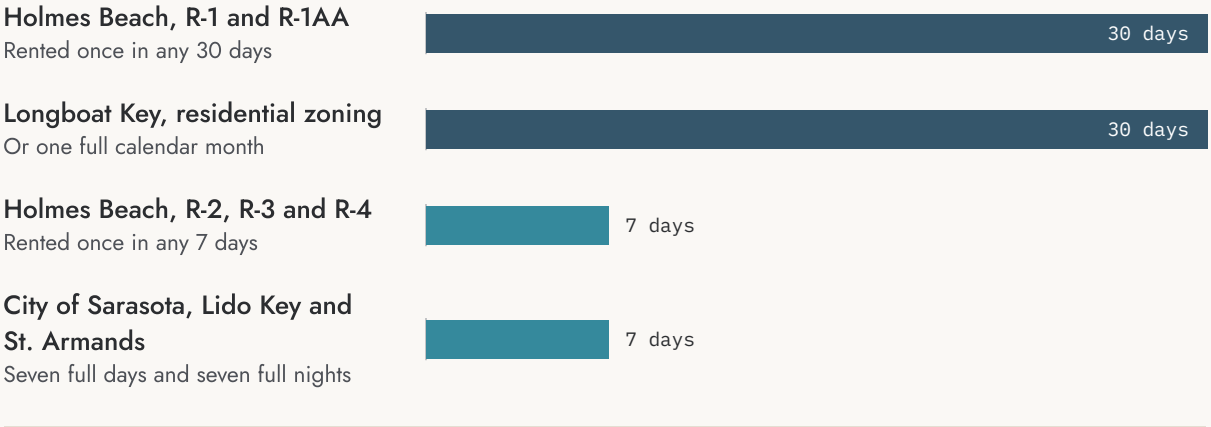
Here are the shortest stays side by side. Look up the zoning district first. The number follows the district, not the island.

Two islands can share a beach and not a rule. On one, a week is fine. Next door, a month is the floor.

FIG. 07 · THE NUMBERS

How short a rental can be, by district

Each bar is one district's shortest stay, in days. Longer bars mean longer stays.



Anna Maria's page doesn't give a number. Bradenton Beach counts how often a home is rented, not how long each stay is. Siesta Key's rule is the county's, which we couldn't open.

Source: City of Holmes Beach, Vacation rental certificates; Town of Longboat Key, Short term rentals; City of Sarasota, Vacation rentals

A condominium can set a longer floor on top of the city's. Read its documents too.

08

Before you make an offer on an island

Use this list each time you look at a house on an island. The first three steps only take a few minutes.

FIG. 08 · THE CHECKLIST

Seven things to check before you make an offer

Go in order. Each step helps with the next one.

- ☐ 01 **Find out which government runs the lot**
  A city, a town or the county. On Anna Maria Island and Siesta Key, it changes along the island.
- ☐ 02 **Look up the zoning district for the exact lot**
  The rule follows the district, not the island or the street.
- ☐ 03 **Read the rental rule for that district**
  The shortest stay, the registration, and the inspection before you can advertise.
- ☐ 04 **Read the height rule, and where it's measured from**
  The crown of the road, the flood protection elevation, or the minimum FEMA elevation.
- ☐ 05 **Ask the building department about the 50 percent rule**
  How much work the building's value allows before it must be rebuilt to today's rules. Get it in writing.
- ☐ 06 **Check the flood zone and ask for the elevation certificate**
  Our flood guide walks through both.
- ☐ 07 **If it's a condominium, read its documents**
  They can set a longer shortest stay than the city's.

Source: Each step comes from the section it sums up. The sources are listed there and at the end of this guide

09

Your island notes for one house

Fill in the right side for the house you're looking at.

Address	Write it here
Island, and the government that runs it	City, town or county
Zoning district	From the city or county map
Shortest rental stay	Days, for that district
Rental registration or certificate	What it takes, and the inspection
Height limit, and measured from	Feet, and the starting line
The 50 percent rule	The building department's written answer
Flood zone and elevation certificate	From our flood guide's checklist
Condominium documents	Their shortest stay, if any

Sources

1. City of Anna Maria, Vacation rental rules and regulations
   www.cityofannamaria.com/208/Vacation-Rental-Rules-Regulations
2. City of Holmes Beach, Vacation rental certificates
   www.holmesbeachfl.org/departments/vacation_rental_certificates.php
3. City of Bradenton Beach, Common code violations
   www.cityofbradentonbeach.com/165/Common-Code-Violations
4. Town of Longboat Key, Ad valorem taxes
   www.longboatkey.org/434/Ad-valorem-Taxes
5. City of Sarasota, Vacation rentals
   www.sarasotafl.gov/government/development-services/vacation-rentals
6. Sarasota City Plan, Environmental protection and coastal islands chapter, adopted May 1, 2017 (PDF)
   www.sarasotafl.gov/files/assets/city/v/1/planning/documents/chapter4_environmentalplanaccessible.pdf
7. FEMA, Substantial improvement (glossary)
   www.fema.gov/glossary/substantial-improvement
8. City of Holmes Beach, Flood and hurricane protection information
   www.holmesbeachfl.org/i_want_to/flood___hurricane_protection_information.php
9. Manatee County, Floodplain management
   www.mymanatee.org/departments/building___development_services/floodplain_management
10. City of Holmes Beach, Comprehensive plan, adopted June 14, 2022 (PDF)
    cms9files1.revize.com/holmesbeachfl/Comprehensive%20Plan%20Adopted%202022.pdf
11. City of Bradenton Beach, R-2 district sheet from the land development code (PDF)
    www.cityofbradentonbeach.com/DocumentCenter/View/6224/R-2-Zoning-revised-02-06-20-PDF
12. Town of Longboat Key, Elections
    www.longboatkey.org/281/Elections
13. Town of Longboat Key, Short term rentals
    www.longboatkey.org/221/Short-Term-Rentals
14. Town of Longboat Key, Residential rental registry
    www.longboatkey.org/243/Residential-Rental-Registry
15. City of Sarasota, Zoning
    www.sarasotafl.gov/government/development-services/zoning
16. Sarasota County, scgov.net
17. Sarasota County, Code of ordinances (Municode)
    library.municode.com/fl/sarasota_county/codes/code_of_ordinances
18. Florida Statutes 509.032(7), local regulation of vacation rentals (2026)
    www.flsenate.gov/Laws/Statutes/2026/509.032

This guide is general information about places and rules, written for Lakewood Ranch · Sarasota · Bradenton. It is not legal, insurance or tax advice, and nothing in it is a figure for any particular house.

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Send us an address.

We'll find the district, read the rule with you, and call the city when the page doesn't say. If you'd rather do it yourself, this guide is the order we'd do it in.

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